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merely prevent failure but enable sustainable success. Incorporating such principles into the UK Code would require reframing the “comply or explain” model into a “govern and demonstrate” approach, where firms not only comply but also substantiate how their governance contributes to long-term value creation and social welfare.

To advance good corporate governance, several revisions are recommended.

First, introduce mandatory ESG oversight under audit committee responsibilities, supported by periodic assurance statements.

Second, codify minimum diversity expectations and transparent reporting on board composition and inclusion policies.

Third, adopt integrated sustainability reporting aligned with CSRD (2023) standards to improve comparability and investor confidence.

Finally, establish a board ethics framework requiring disclosure of how governance practices align with organisational purpose and societal values.

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Germany's Corporate Governance Code (2023) equally exemplifies the institutionalisation of ESG oversight. It requires supervisory boards to monitor sustainability risks and mandates diversity in both gender and skills composition. This codification acknowledges that stakeholder inclusivity enhances strategic oversight and mitigates systemic risks. By comparison, the UK's 2024 Code remains silent on ESG responsibilities, despite growing global consensus that sustainability and diversity are intrinsic to governance quality (OECD, 2023). A revision incorporating mandatory ESG assurance within audit committee duties, supported by independent verification, would align the UK framework with international norms and investor expectations.

Similarly, Japan's Corporate Governance Code (2021) introduced explicit diversity targets and board training requirements to enhance collective competence and innovation. The inclusion of "independent outside directors" ensures broader perspectives and reduces insular decision-making. Empirical studies show that Japanese firms adopting these reforms exhibit stronger market valuations and stakeholder confidence (Miyajima and Nitta, 2022). The UK could emulate this approach by setting measurable diversity thresholds, as recommended by Parker (2023) and FTSE Women Leaders (2024) reviews, and by embedding director development programmes within governance expectations.

Beyond national codes, the OECD Principles of Corporate Governance (2023) and the G20/OECD Corporate Governance Framework provide a global benchmark. These principles emphasise accountability to a broad stakeholder base, transparent ESG disclosure, and alignment between corporate purpose and societal interests. The OECD advocates that governance systems should not merely prevent failure but enable sustainable success. Incorporating such principles into the UK Code would require reframing the "comply or explain" model into a "govern and demonstrate" approach, where firms not only comply but also substantiate how their governance contributes to long-term value creation and social welfare.

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Conclusion

The 2024 UK Corporate Governance Code strengthens procedural accountability through its renewed focus on internal controls, but falls short of embodying the broader ideals of good governance. By excluding sustainability, diversity, and ESG oversight, the Code narrows governance to compliance rather than stewardship. International frameworks, from South Africa's King IV to Germany's ESG mandates, demonstrate that ethical leadership and inclusivity are now governance imperatives. For the UK to reclaim its pioneering role, future revisions must integrate these dimensions, ensuring governance that is effective, transparent, socially responsible, forward-looking, and aligned with global expectations.

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